

Designing a Community-Building App for First-Year College Students

A mixed-methods UX research and product design project exploring how first-year students build connection and belonging in residence halls.

Starting college can be exciting, but it can also be isolating. For first-year students living in residence halls, the transition often means navigating a new environment, forming friendships from scratch, and figuring out where to turn for social and emotional support.

Through Design for America, my team explored how we might better support first-year University of Washington students as they adjusted to residence hall life. Our research focused on understanding where students felt disconnected, what support systems they actually used, and how a digital product could encourage more meaningful in-person connection.

Project Snapshot

Project / Client: Design for America, University of Washington residence hall experience

Timeline: September 2019 – May 2020

Role: Team Lead, UX Researcher, UX/UI Designer

Team / Stakeholders: 6 student designers, UW residents, residence hall stakeholders / administrators

Problem Space: Supporting first-year students as they transitioned into residence hall life and worked to build community

Methods: Secondary research, user interviews, survey research, affinity mapping, ideation, information architecture, prototyping, usability testing

Tools: Figma, Miro, Google Forms, Google Workspace

Outputs: Research synthesis, refined design question, design principles, IA, low-fidelity prototypes, [high-fidelity mobile app prototype](#), and [final presentation](#)

Outcome / Impact: Designed Meetzap, a mobile app concept that helped first-year students discover events, match with peers, and coordinate low-pressure in-person meetups

Focus Areas: Student experience, community building, social connection, product design, mixed-methods research, trust and safety

About Design for America

Design for America is a student-led design organization focused on applying human-centered design to social challenges on college campuses and in local communities.

For this project, our team focused on the first-year residence hall experience at the University of Washington, with an emphasis on belonging, social connection, and the transition into college life.

The Challenge

Residence halls are often designed with community in mind, but that does not mean community happens automatically.

First-year students are navigating a major life transition: moving away from familiar support systems, adjusting to a new academic environment, and trying to build relationships in an unfamiliar place. While Resident Advisors are available on each floor, their role is often centered on safety, logistics, and support — not necessarily creating low-pressure opportunities for students to socialize and form genuine friendships.

Our initial research question was:

How might we better support UW first-year students who are staying in residence halls and navigating their transition into a new community?

My Role

As team lead, I helped guide the project from early research through final prototype and presentation. I contributed across the full design process, including research planning, interviews, survey analysis, synthesis, ideation, prototyping, and visual design.

A major part of my role was also helping the team stay aligned through an ambiguous, long-term project. Early on, I gave the group a high degree of creative freedom, but I later realized we needed clearer structure to keep momentum. I adjusted by creating broader project timelines, smaller individual deliverables, and more focused working sessions, which helped the team move more efficiently from research to design.

Research Approach

We used a mixed-methods approach to understand the social and emotional experience of first-year students living in UW residence halls.

Our research included:

Secondary research to better understand the broader college transition experience

6 qualitative interviews with UW residents and administrators

91 survey responses from UW residents and administrators

Affinity mapping and color coding to identify recurring themes across interview transcripts and survey responses

We used qualitative research to understand the emotional context behind students' experiences, then used survey data to identify which patterns were showing up more broadly across the residence hall community.

Key Research Findings

1. Community was valued, but often missing.

Students wanted to feel connected to their residence hall communities, but many did not experience a strong sense of belonging. From our survey, we found that **1 in 3 students did not report a strong sense of community** during their time in the residence halls. The average community rating was **2.65 out of 5**.

This suggested that community was not just a “nice to have” — it was a meaningful gap in the first-year experience.

2. Students did not always see RAs as social connectors.

Residents knew RAs were available for safety, logistics, and formal support, but they did not necessarily view them as a natural path to friendship or social connection.

At the same time, RAs wanted to help residents build community. This revealed an opportunity to create less formal, more approachable ways for students and RAs to connect.

3. Stressors extended beyond social life.

Students' residence hall experience was shaped by more than friendship alone. Mental health, academics, and living conditions all contributed to how students felt during their transition into college.

This helped us avoid designing a solution that treated social connection as isolated from the broader student experience.

4. Friends were the most common go-to resource.

When students needed support, they were most likely to turn to friends. This finding helped us focus on peer connection as a key part of helping students feel more comfortable, supported, and integrated into campus life.

Refining the Design Scope

Our early research question focused broadly on supporting students through the transition into residence hall life. As we synthesized our findings, we realized the strongest opportunity was more specific: helping students build meaningful peer connections through shared interests, activities, and in-person interactions.

We refined our design question to:

How might we increase face-to-face interactions and build community among students living in University of Washington residence halls?

This shift helped us move from a broad student support challenge to a clearer product opportunity.

Include different social styles.

Some students are comfortable introducing themselves to strangers, while others need a lower-pressure way to engage. We wanted the experience to support both introverted and extroverted students.

Connect students through shared context.

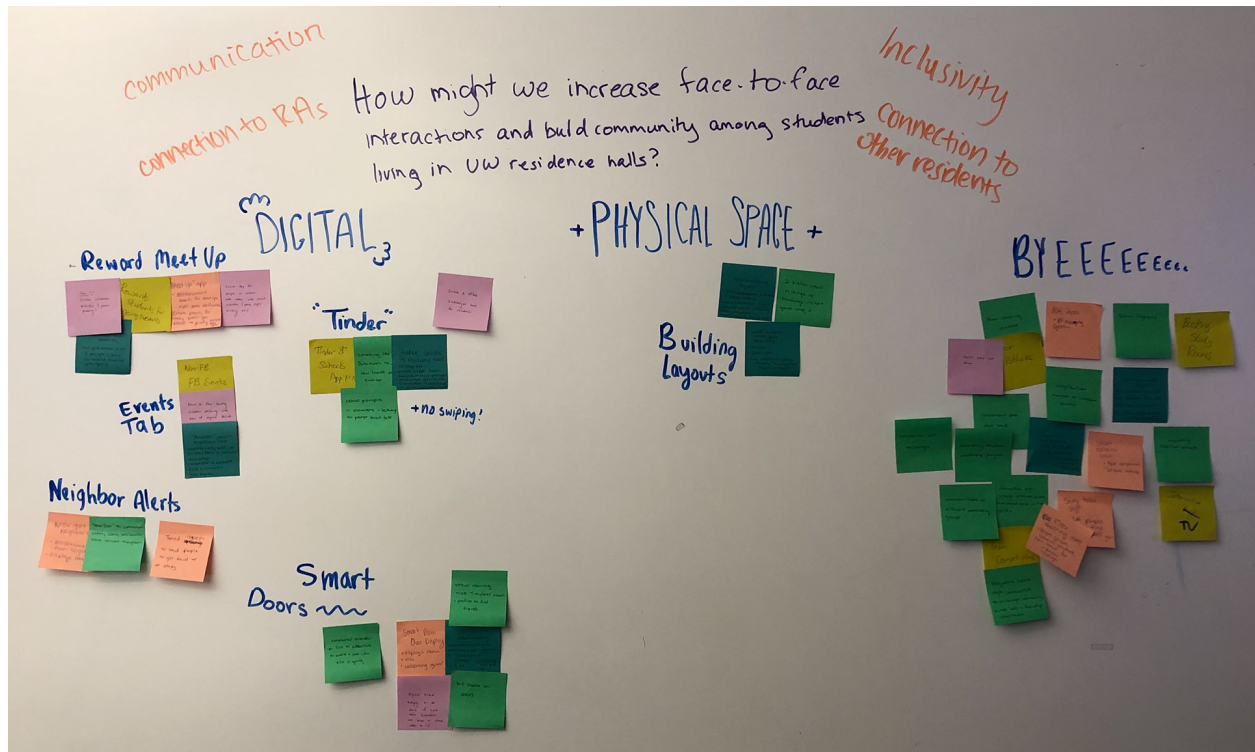
Students were more likely to feel comfortable meeting people when they had something in common, whether that was a class, hobby, hometown, event, or study goal.

Ideation

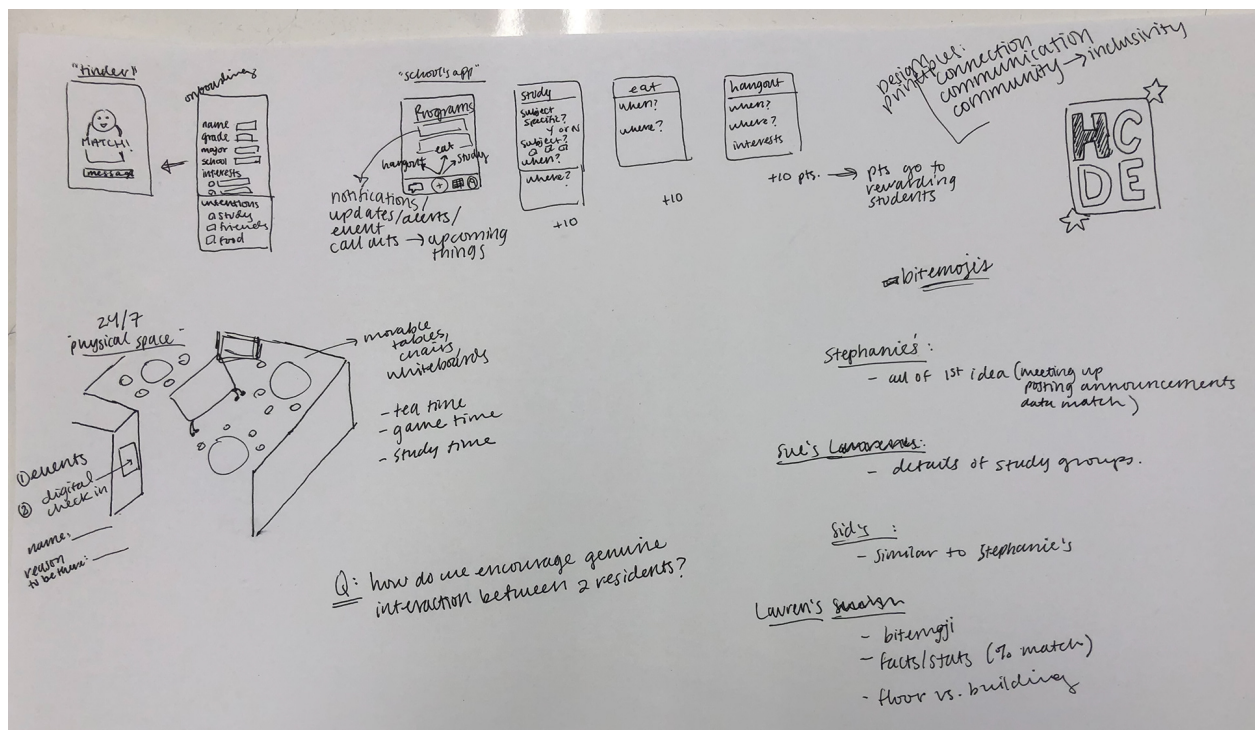
During ideation, we explored both digital and physical ways to support connection in residence halls. We organized divergent ideas through affinity mapping, then moved into more focused concept development.

Some ideas centered on physical spaces and in-person programming, while others focused on digital tools that could help students discover opportunities and coordinate meetups. Although a non-digital solution was appealing, we recognized that it would be difficult to execute within the scope and resources of the project.

We ultimately chose to design a mobile app because it gave us a feasible way to support discovery, matching, communication, and event participation in one experience.



Affinity Diagram of Divergent Ideas



Some of my convergent ideation sketches

Caption: We used affinity mapping to organize early ideas and identify which concepts best addressed students' social connection pain points.

Information Architecture

Before moving into detailed screens, we mapped the app's information architecture to understand how students would move through the experience.

The app needed to support several core actions:

Create a profile

Discover events and announcements

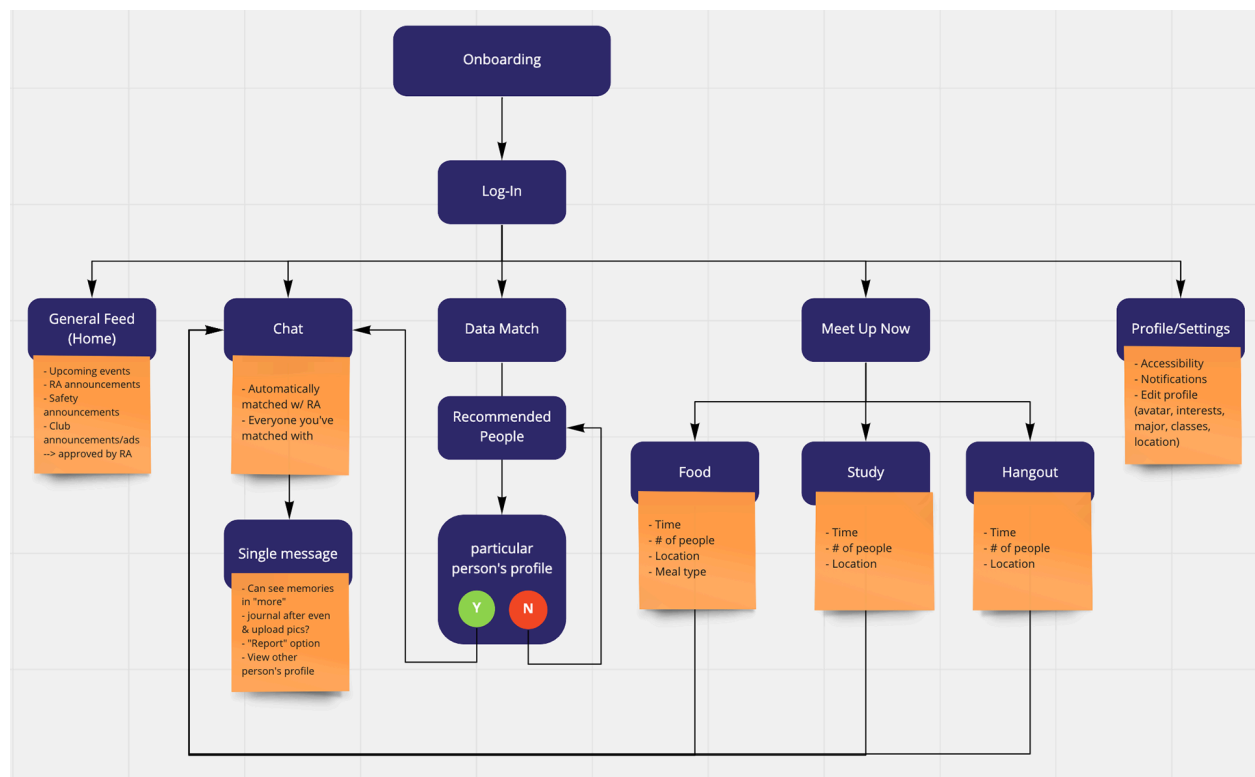
Find compatible peers

Coordinate meetups

Chat safely before meeting

Encourage students to spend time together offline

This structure helped us define the major areas of the app and make sure each feature supported the broader goal of building face-to-face community.



Caption: The information architecture helped us organize the product around discovery, matching, communication, and in-person connection.

Visual Design Direction

For the visual direction, we wanted the app to feel friendly, approachable, and calm. We explored color and typography choices that could support the emotional goals of the product.

We chose a palette of blues and oranges because the combination balanced trust and approachability with energy and playfulness. We also selected rounded, friendly typography to make the product feel less formal and more welcoming for first-year students.



Rubik

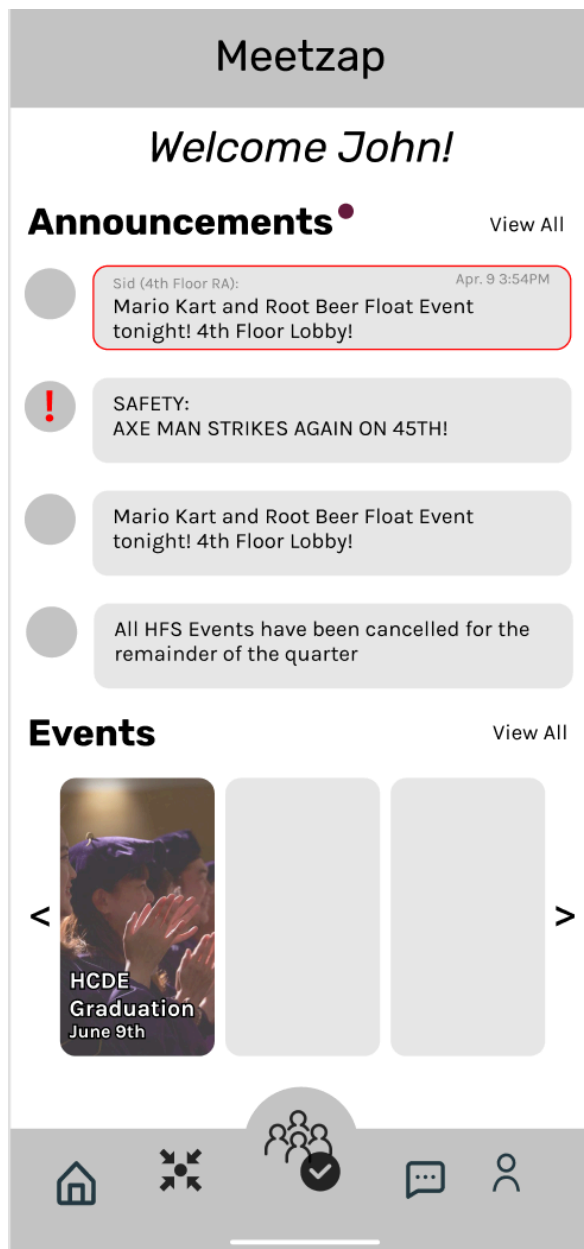
Karla

Caption: *We used color and typography to create a visual system that felt welcoming, calm, and student-friendly.*

Prototyping and Usability Testing

We created multiple rounds of low-fidelity prototypes in Figma and gathered feedback from potential users.

Early usability feedback helped us identify opportunities to make the navigation more intuitive, especially around the icon system and menu bar. Based on this feedback, we refined the app structure and interaction patterns before moving into high-fidelity designs.



Your Matches



Amy Lambert

2 minutes ago
44% match!

view more



Mathew Carr

8 minutes ago
72% match!

view more



Karina Marie

1 day ago
100% match!

view more



Amy Smith

3 days ago
85% match!

view more

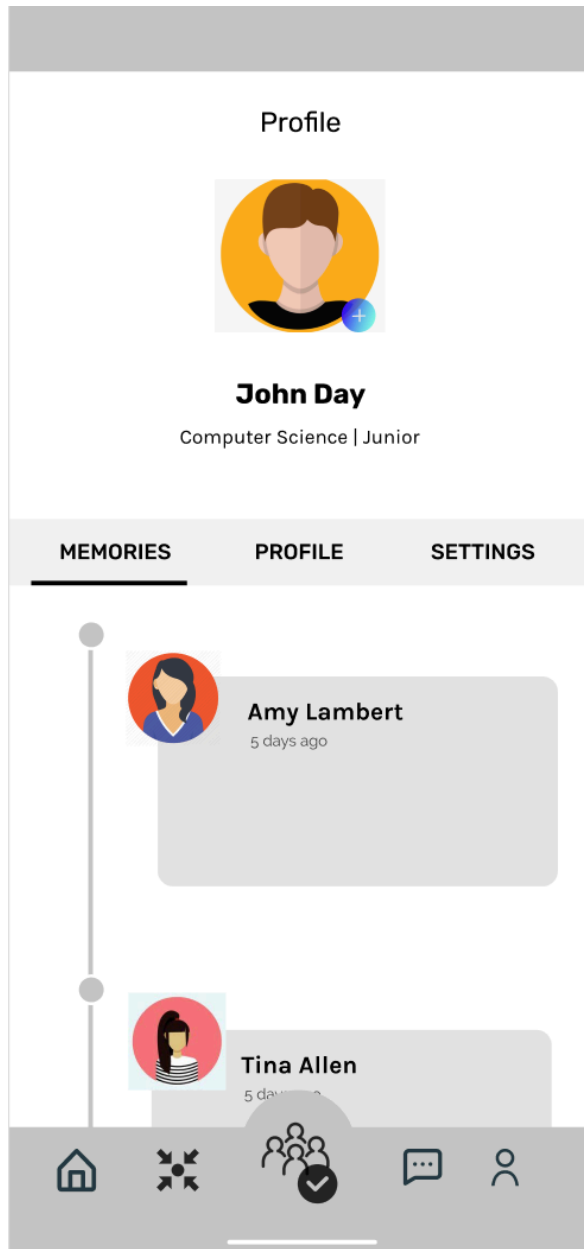


Grace Hesky

2/25/2020
79% match!

view more





Caption: *Early prototype feedback helped us simplify navigation and make core actions easier to understand.*

Ethical Considerations

One of our most important design decisions was how to represent student profiles.

Because the app was designed to help students meet new people, we wanted users to feel safe and confident. At the same time, we were cautious about making the experience too photo-driven. We did not want students to make quick judgments based on appearance, especially because the app was intended to support friendship and community — not dating.

After discussing the tradeoffs, we chose to use avatars instead of profile photos. This allowed for basic identification while reducing the likelihood that students would make snap judgments based on appearance. The decision helped keep the experience focused on personality, shared interests, and comfort rather than visual comparison.



Caption: *We chose avatars over profile photos to balance safety, identification, and inclusive connection.*

Final Concept: Meetzap

Our final concept was **Meetzap**, a mobile app designed to help first-year students connect with peers, discover residence hall events, and turn digital introductions into in-person interactions.

The app included:

Onboarding for first-time users

Customizable student profiles

RA announcements

Upcoming residence hall events

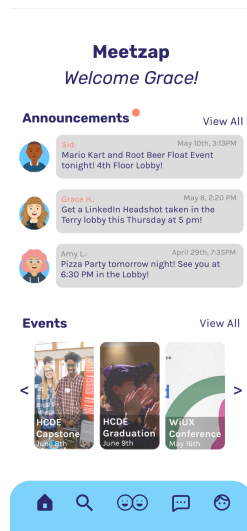
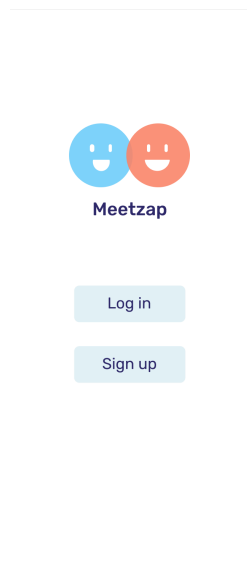
Peer matching

Chat functionality

Meetup coordination

Offline Mode to encourage in-person connection

The goal was not to replace in-person community, but to make it easier for students to find and create those moments.



< Folders

Chat

Mathew C. (RA)

2 minutes ago

Message contents...

Amy L.

2 minutes ago

Message contents...

Layla T.

2 minutes ago

Message contents...

Blorange

2 minutes ago

Message contents...

Susie R.

2 minutes ago

Message contents...

Delete



Meet Up Now

Looking for people to
study, grab a meal
with, attend an event,
or just hangout with?

Find a buddy now! >



Your Matches

NEW

ACCEPTED

Amy L.

2 minutes ago

44% match!

view more

Claire C.

8 minutes ago

72% match!

view more

Susie R.

1 day ago

100% match!

view more

Alina S.

3 days ago

85% match!

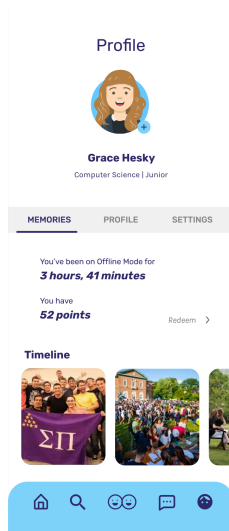
view more

Leon T.

February 26th, 2020

79% match!





Caption: *The final prototype helped students discover events, connect with peers, and coordinate low-pressure in-person meetups.*

Key Feature: Peer Matching

One of Meetzap's core features was peer matching.

During onboarding, students could share information about their interests, classes, hometown, goals, and preferences. The matching concept was designed to help students find other residents with shared context, making it easier to start a conversation.

Once students were matched, they could view each other's profiles and decide whether to accept the match. If both users accepted, chat would become available so they could connect before meeting in person.

The goal of this feature was to reduce the anxiety of introducing yourself to a stranger while also expanding students' ability to meet people beyond their immediate floor or existing social circle.

9:41



Your Matches

NEW

ACCEPTED



Amy L.

2 minutes ago

44% match!

view more



Claire C.

8 minutes ago

72% match!

view more



Susie R.

1 day ago

100% match!

view more



Alina S.

3 days ago

85% match!

view more



Leon T.

Feburary 26th, 2020

79% match!



Key Feature: Meet Up Now

The **Meet Up Now** feature was designed for moments when students wanted to do something with others but did not feel comfortable asking publicly.

A student could select:

What they wanted to do

Where they wanted to meet

When they wanted to meet

How many people they wanted to join

The app would then help connect them with another student or group interested in the same activity.

This feature was designed to support low-pressure social planning, whether a student wanted to attend an event, grab food, study, or explore campus with someone else.

Key Feature: Offline Mode

We wanted Meetzap to encourage real connection, not just more screen time.

Offline Mode was designed to activate when students met up in person. It included light conversation prompts for students who wanted help starting a conversation, while also encouraging users to stay off their phones during the meetup.

The concept included a reward system where students could earn points or prizes for spending time in Offline Mode. This helped reinforce the larger behavior we wanted to support: using the app as a starting point for real-world connection.

9:41



Meet Up Now

Searching for a

You've been matched
with a friend!

Tap accept to meet up



Accept

Cancel



We'll notify you when we've found a
Husky who matches your interests!



Cancel Search



Final Presentation

At the end of the project, we presented our final poster, [slide deck](#), and [prototype](#) to fellow UW Design for America members, UX professionals from Artefact, and members of the national Design for America community.

The final prototype demonstrated how Meetzap could support first-year students through onboarding, peer matching, event discovery, meetup coordination, and offline engagement.

MEETZAP

Find and connect with new friends on campus

Kerry Horton, Lauren Abbott, Sue Chen,
Sid Jain, Stephanie Wong, Catherine Zeng

PROBLEM

Students at the University of Washington value finding community on campus. However, building community in residence halls is notoriously difficult. This lack of community is exacerbated by not feeling connected to campus resources, academic stress, and finding people to attend campus events with.

On average, students rated the
sense of community
in residents halls as

2.65 / 5

**Friends are the most
impactful resource**

when students seek support

DESIGN QUESTION

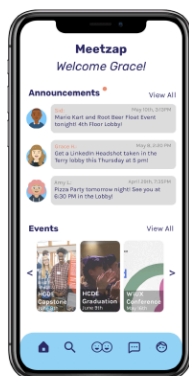
How might we increase face-to-face interactions
and build community among students living in
UW residence halls?

SOLUTION

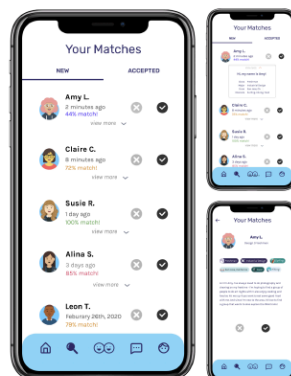
Meetz ap is an app that enables residents to meet one another and stay connected. Its main functionality is to match students based on commonalities and encourage them to meet in-person. Additional features include discovering events & announcements, receiving chat prompts, connecting to a new buddy, and customizing a personal profile. **Meetzap leverages technology to encourage genuine connections and community building offline.**

DESIGN PRINCIPLES

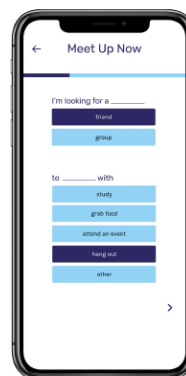
1. Foster simple communication
2. Connect RAs and residents
3. Connect residents with each other
4. Include students of every personality



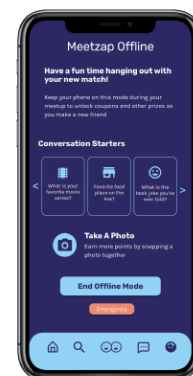
Home-page displays RA announcements and campus alerts, and campus events.



Your Matches page shows people the user has been matched up with based on similar interests, majors, and/or hometowns. User has the ability to view more about the person and the ability to accept or decline the match up.



Meet Up Now page allows user to request a buddy or group to go [study, grab food, attend an event, hang out] day of.



Offline mode can be enabled when the user attends an event to encourage the user to engage with the people around them. User earns points when in this mode.

DESIGN *for* AMERICA

Caption: *We presented the final concept to UW DFA members, UX professionals, and Design for America representatives.*

Reflection

This project was an early lesson in research-led product design, ethical decision-making, and team leadership.

As team lead, I initially gave the group a high degree of creative freedom so each person could contribute their own perspective. Over time, I realized the team needed more structure to stay aligned and make progress through a long, ambiguous project.

I adjusted by creating clearer timelines, smaller individual deliverables, and more focused working sessions. That shift improved participation, made meetings more productive, and helped the team move from research synthesis to final prototype more effectively.

Looking back, this project helped shape how I think about research today: the strongest solutions often come from narrowing the problem, understanding the emotional context behind user behavior, and designing for the real-world moments where people need support.

What I'd Do Differently Today

If I were approaching this project now, I would spend more time validating the riskiest assumptions behind the concept.

For example, I would want to better understand:

Whether students would trust a peer-matching tool connected to residence hall life

What safety expectations students and administrators would have before meeting in person

Whether students would actually use Offline Mode or perceive it as unnecessary

How RAs could participate without making the experience feel too formal or monitored

I would also test the concept earlier with students through task-based usability testing and lightweight concept testing before moving into high-fidelity design.

Even with those limitations, this project gave me valuable experience leading a team through ambiguity, using research to narrow a broad problem space, and designing a product concept around belonging, trust, and in-person connection.

Short Version for the Project Card

Designing a Community-Building App for First-Year Students

Led a 6-person student design team through mixed-methods research, synthesis, prototyping, and usability testing to explore how first-year UW students build belonging in residence halls. Designed Meetzap, a mobile app concept that helped students discover events, match with peers, and coordinate low-pressure in-person meetups.

UX Research · Product Design · Mixed Methods · Survey Research · User Interviews · Affinity Mapping · Prototyping · Usability Testing · Student Experience · Community Building · Trust & Safety